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ECONOMY

Nordic countries are the happiest in the world. 2 Finnish recruiters explain why their work culture and lifestyle are so attractive.

By **Hendrikje Rudnick** and **Nathan Rennolds**, **Business Insider Deutschland**

"Every person can enjoy an education here. It doesn't depend on whether your parents can afford it or not," a Finnish recruiter said. Geber86/Getty Images

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Apr 19, 2022, 10:34 AM MESZ

- **Nordic countries consistently come highest in world happiness rankings.**
- **Two Finnish recruiters working in Sweden told Insider why this is the case.**
- **They cited flatter hierarchies at work, more flexible working hours, and free education.**

This is an edited, translated version of an article that originally appeared on April 8, 2022.

When the World Happiness Report is published each year, Nordic countries traditionally occupy five of the top 10 places — people from Finland, Sweden, Norway, Denmark, and Iceland consistently rank as happier than those from other countries.

In the 2022 report, Finland was ranked as the happiest country, followed by Denmark and Iceland. Sweden and Norway are also in the top 10 — in seventh and eighth place respectively — with only Switzerland, the Netherlands, and Luxembourg in between. The US came in 16th, one place behind Canada.

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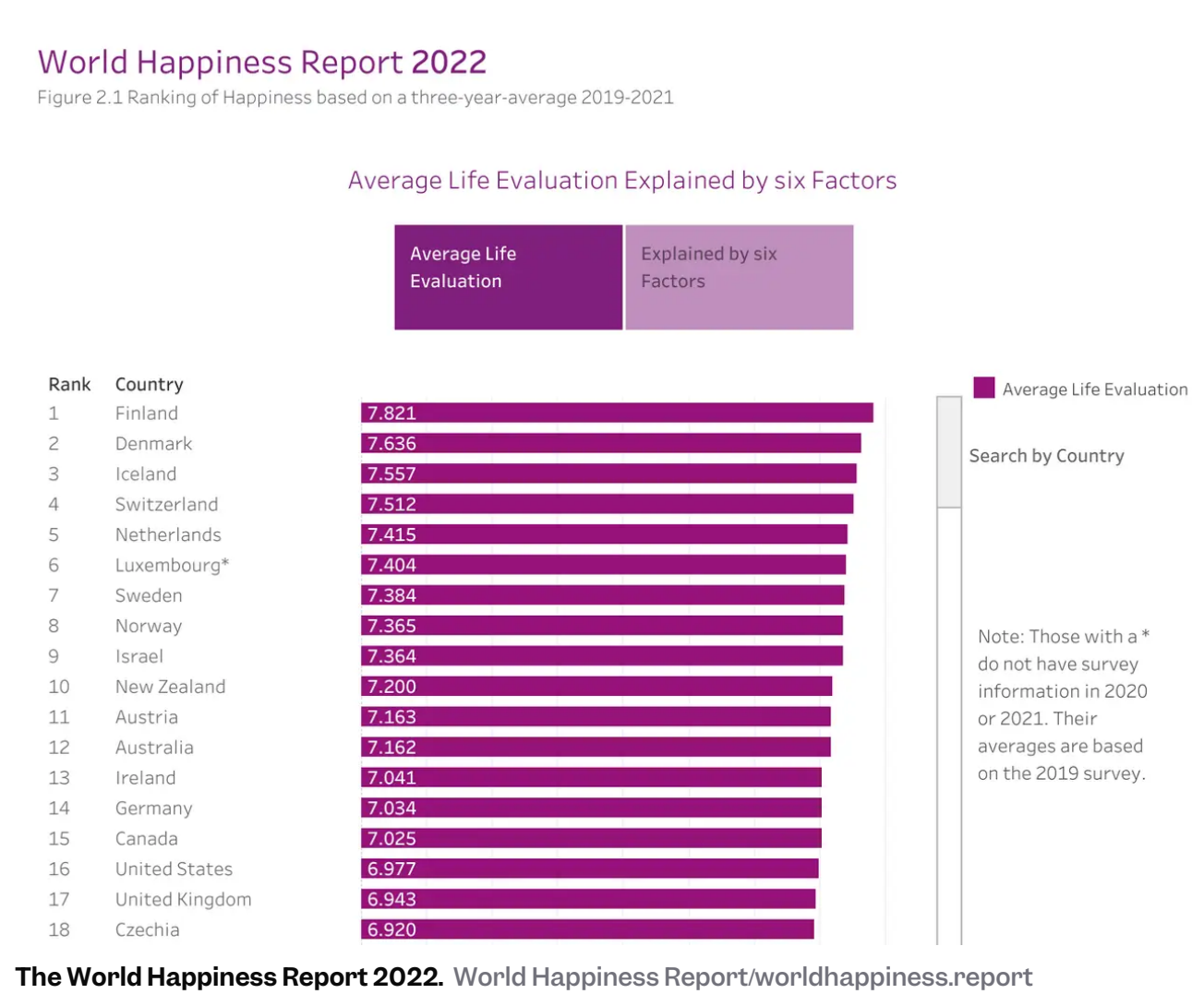

The World Happiness Report 2022. World Happiness Report/worldhappiness.report

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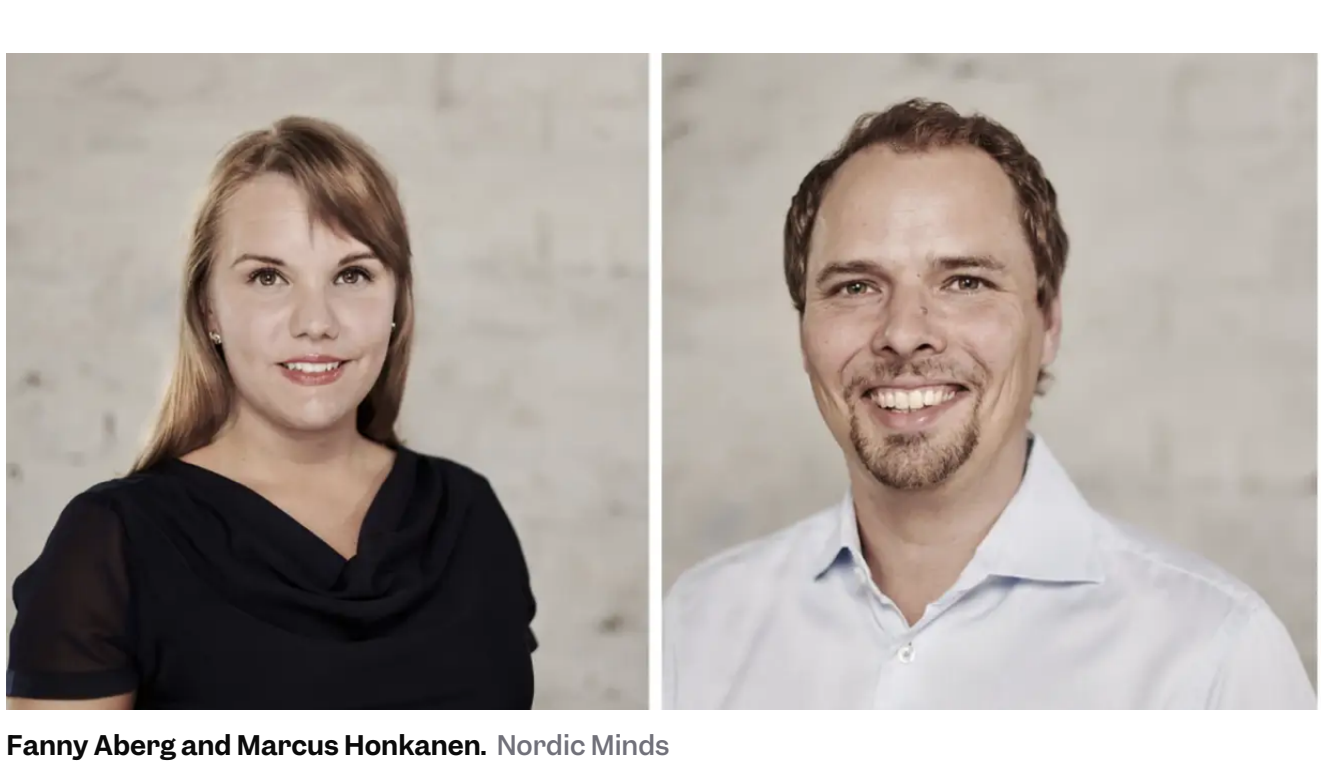
Fanny Aberg and Marcus Honkanen are originally from Finland, but they now live and work in Sweden.

They run Nordic Minds, an executive recruitment company with offices in Stockholm and Helsinki as well as Hamburg and Düsseldorf, in Germany.

In an interview with Insider, Aberg and Honkanen described the Nordic mindset and the differences in lifestyle and working culture compared with other countries.



Fanny Aberg and Marcus Honkanen. Nordic Minds

Aberg said that in Nordic countries, "family always comes first."

"That means working hours are based on when you want to spend time with your family," she added. It's perfectly normal to turn off your computer at 4 in the afternoon and pick up children from daycare, spend the afternoon with them, and eat dinner together, she continued. "If there's still work to do, you can always finish it in the evening after the kids are in bed."

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"Sweden in particular is a pioneer here, I would say. There are no attendance requirements or anything like that," Honkanen said.

"People have more control over their own happiness," he added.

When asked which words described the "Nordic culture," Aberg said open, honest, personal, and transparent.

"At work, we're informal but professional," she said. "If you run into someone in the hallway and they're wearing jeans and a hoodie, it could be a new junior employee or it could be the CEO."

She added that, for the most part, people are on first-name terms.

Companies in Nordic countries tend to be less hierarchical, Aberg said. "Here, everyone gets a say, whether junior level or management. The flatter hierarchies also mean that we can work more efficiently."

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There are also a lot of meetings, Aberg said, but these are often more casual. She cited the Swedish tradition known as "fika," which is essentially a coffee and pastry break with friends.

Aberg said that, in Sweden, a clear line is drawn between work and leisure "in the sense that we don't take our work home with us."

Anyone who has ever taken a vacation in Nordic countries knows the cost of living is high there, she continued, but this doesn't mean that workers earn more. "On the contrary," she said. "The way our hierarchies are flat, there's not as much of a pay difference when you get to higher positions."

She said that for management positions in smaller and medium-sized companies, employees can earn up to 10,000 euros (about $10,900) a month, plus bonuses. In 2021, employees in Sweden earned an average of 36,100 Swedish krona per month, which is about $3,800.

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Honkanen said people can afford to live there despite the high costs because its social system includes all citizens. "Social insurance includes, for example, health, parental, disability, pension, and occupational accident insurance," he said.

Free education is another important factor: "Every person can enjoy an education here. It doesn't depend on whether your parents can afford it or not," Aberg said.

She added that parents also get a lot of support, such as the option of putting a child in full-day daycare if they both are working.

The pair agreed that the Nordic countries' culture showed the rest of the world it could "loosen up" and let people "show who you really are and don't play a character in your workplace."

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"I think it's important to develop a corporate culture based on trust rather than control," Honkanen said.

People should also focus more on their lives, their families, and their free time, Aberg said. "Success at work is not the key to happiness," she added.

Read the original article on Business Insider Deutschland.

This post originally appeared on Business Insider Deutschland and has been translated from German.

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Nathan Rennolds is Business Insider's UK Weekend Editor. He previously worked on BI's newsletter team. He graduated from University College London with a Bachelor's degr…
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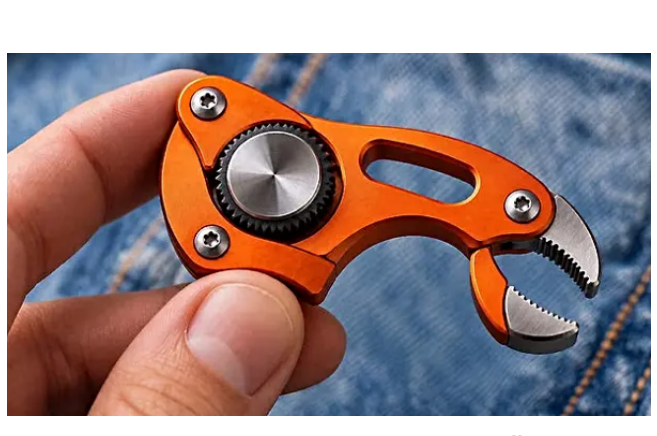

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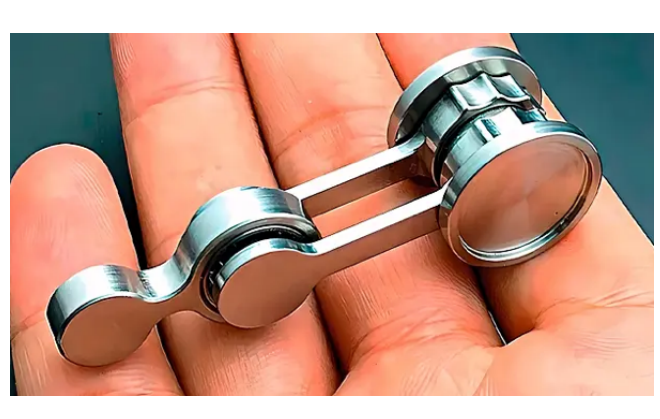

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